The New Nationalism

Theodore Roosevelt · Osawatomie, Kansas · August 31, 1910 · excerpts

Source: Theodore Roosevelt Center, theodoreroosevelt center.org; speech reprinted in The New Nationalism (1910).

Two years out of office and growing restless under his successor Taft, Theodore Roosevelt gave this speech at the dedication of a John Brown memorial. It launched his progressive agenda — graduated income and inheritance taxes, federal regulation of corporations, and stronger executive power — and previewed his 1912 Bull Moose campaign. He framed strong federal action as the necessary modern equivalent of Hamiltonian nationalism.

Connect: TR's push for a strong federal government echoes Hamilton's original Federalist argument (Class 6). Trace one line from Hamilton to TR.

Key Passages

On corporate power

> The absence of effective State, and, especially, national, restraint upon unfair money-getting has tended to create a small class of enormously wealthy and economically powerful men, whose chief object is to hold and increase their power. The prime need is to change the conditions which enable these men to accumulate power which it is not for the general welfare that they should hold or exercise.

The Square Deal

> When I say that I am for the square deal, I mean not merely that I stand for fair play under the present rules of the game, but that I stand for having those rules changed so as to work for a more substantial equality of opportunity and of reward.

New Nationalism

> The New Nationalism puts the national need before sectional or personal advantage. … It demands that representative government … represent all the people rather than any one class or section of the people.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	The Progressive Era; tension between Roosevelt's progressive wing and Taft's conservatives was splitting the Republican Party.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	A crowd of Kansas farmers and veterans at the John Brown memorial, plus the national press and progressive Republicans.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Theodore Roosevelt, a former Republican president who wanted to reclaim leadership of reform and expand federal power over business.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Historical Reasoning — Comparison (1 pt): Write a thesis comparing TR's New Nationalism with Wilson's New Freedom in the 1912 election.

2. Identify ONE specific reform TR demands and ONE specific reform he does NOT (e.g., women's suffrage).

3. How does this speech anticipate the New Deal a generation later?